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Don't Punish VoIP—Or Its Users

EXECUTIVE EDITOR OF News at eWeek.com Chris Gonsalves has been a strong advocate for the use of VoIP over the years. But he's not too happy with the way some of the products are shaping up and, in his own inimitable style, makes it known

I didn't switch to voice over IP at home because it was better. I went to VoIP because it was cheap. What is it about that equation that the FCC bureaucrats can't fathom? Is it so complicated that hand-wringing columnists and legislators who can't spell "IP" just don't get it?

VoIP service is barely OK. It is marginally better than a military field phone. I can tell when the anti-virus software on my PC is updating in the middle of a phone call. It doesn't work when the power goes out. It sometimes doesn't work when the power comes back on.

What does it cost to buy my acceptance of such transgressions? Sadly, a mere \$24.99 a month. As with my boat and my motorcycle and anything I've ever bought at Wal-Mart, I got what I paid for. The less I pay, the crappier the stuff, and,

more often than not, the happier I am.

Accepting VoIP with all its rough edges was made easier by two decades of passable cellular technology. Cell phones so degraded my expectation of what a phone call should sound like that I'm now willing to accept the clicks and echoes and dropouts on VoIP.

My grandfather would never have stood for the sound quality most of us now find routine when we talk on any phone.

But now government agents want to take away my cheap, crappy phone service. The reason, they claim, is because I've been left in grave danger by unscrupulous VoIP vendors that are denying me full access to 911.

Forget about the fact that I agreed to VoIP's method of routing 911 calls at least a dozen times during the sign-up process.

You can even forget that a snippy Verizon rep berated me for cancelling my land lines with the warning that I'd be cooked in an emergency.

"Yeah, but \$24.99 a month!", I shouted.

"It's your call," the rep said.

The bottom line is I don't care. And neither do most VoIP users if my e-mail and the Internet forums are any indication. Everybody knows what VoIP is and what it isn't. Still, the FCC now says VoIP service providers must solve the 911 location problem for the lowest common denominator of VoIP users.

If the FCC really just wanted to keep us safe, why couldn't it have pushed the Bells to make certain that all cancelled land line jacks still support 911 calls?

They can do that, you know, and, in some places, they do. I could have a hot-line phone in my house for emergencies only, courtesy of Verizon. I'd buy a red phone and put it under a cake dish. Alas, Verizon left me with DC power but no dial tone.

I have no doubt an answer will be found that saves VoIP in some fashion. The service will be dumbed down. It'll lose its portability features. It will probably be more expensive, but it's not going away. The Bells will get a piece of the action.

Still, I wish the government would concern itself less with the business model of the Bells and extend to me my right to get exactly what I pay for, especially when I'm not paying that much.



Psst!

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Wrestlemania?

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